PayPal AI Hackathon!

Opportunity Overview

Organizer: PayPal
Competition Type: Global Online Hackathon
Format: Online
Team Participation: Individual or Team
Eligibility: Participants above the legal age of majority in their country of residence
Geographic Eligibility: All countries/territories, subject to standard exceptions
Registration Deadline: 13 November 2026, 1:30 AM GMT+5:30
Total Prize Pool: $67,500+ in cash prizes, plus additional prizes
Core Requirement: The project must meaningfully use both **PayPal and AI**

About The Hackathon

Build What's Next with PayPal and AI is a global online hackathon inviting developers, designers, founders, students, and builders to create something new using **PayPal and AI**.

There are **no prescribed problem statements or fixed tracks**.

Participants can build:

- An AI agent
- An application
- An automation
- A new payment experience
- A business tool
- A social product
- Or something completely new

The fundamental requirement is that the project must **meaningfully use both PayPal and AI**.

Who Can Participate

Participants must:

- Be above the **legal age of majority** in their country of residence.

- Be from an eligible country or territory.
- Comply with the official hackathon rules.

The hackathon is open to developers, designers, founders, **students,** and other builders.

What To Build

Participants must build or update an application that:

- Integrates the **PayPal Developer Platform** using the free sandbox environment.
- Uses an **AI tool, model, or platform** of the participant's choice.
- Meaningfully integrates at least one PayPal technology, API, SDK, product, or developer capability.
- Meaningfully incorporates AI into the project's experience or functionality.
- Demonstrates a working prototype or proof of concept.
- Is sufficiently documented for judges to understand and evaluate.
- Complies with the Official Rules.

Projects can be built individually or as a team.

Participants can either build a **new project** or meaningfully advance an existing project during the hackathon.

AI And Sponsor Tools

Participants can use any AI tool, model, or platform, as long as **PayPal integration is central to the project**.

PayPal also provides access to selected sponsor tools, including:

- AG Grid
- APIMatic
- Astropods
- Bryntum
- Channel3
- Elastic
- KERNEL
- Postman
- Render
- Zapier

Using these sponsor tools is **not mandatory**.

Submission Requirements

Participants must submit the following:

Project

A project built using the required developer tools and meeting the hackathon's project requirements.

Text Description

A description explaining the project's:

- Features
- Functionality
- Overall concept

Functional Demo

Judges must be able to actually run or interact with a working version of the project.

This can be provided through either:

- Clear and complete setup/run instructions in the code repository, allowing judges to build and run the project themselves, or
- A hosted demo URL.

A design mockup, static prototype, or non-functional demo **does not satisfy this requirement**.

Tools Used

Participants must identify the tools used in the project and explain how each tool was used.

Public GitHub Repository

The project must have a **public GitHub repository** containing:

- All source code
- Assets
- Instructions required to run the project

The repository must be public and open source, with a **license file visible at the top of the repository in the About section**.

Demo Video

The demo video must:

- Be **under 3 minutes**.
- Show the project functioning on the device it was built for.
- Be uploaded to **YouTube**.
- Be publicly visible.
- Have its link included in the submission form.
- Not contain third-party trademarks or copyrighted music/material without permission.

Important Project Requirements

The project should:

- Meaningfully integrate at least one PayPal technology, API, SDK, product, or developer capability.
- Meaningfully incorporate AI into the experience or functionality.
- Demonstrate a working prototype or proof of concept.
- Be sufficiently documented.
- Follow the Official Rules.

Prizes

The hackathon offers **$67,500+ in prizes**, along with additional prizes and sponsor awards.

1st Place

$12,000 cash

1 winner

2nd Place

$8,000 cash

1 winner

3rd Place

$5,000 cash

1 winner

Most Creative

$5,000 cash

1 winner

Most Impactful

$5,000 cash

1 winner

Best Demo Delivery

$5,000 cash

1 winner

Best Use of PayPal + AI

$5,000 cash

1 winner

Best Use of Agentic Commerce

$5,000 cash

1 winner

Best Use of AG Grid – 1st Place

$5,000 cash

1 winner

Best Use of AG Grid – 2nd Place

$2,000 cash

1 winner

Best Use of AG Grid – 3rd Place

$1,000 cash

3 winners

Best Use of APIMatic

$1,000 cash

3 winners

Additionally, winners receive **6 months of APIMatic business subscription**.

Best Use of Bryntum

$1,000 cash

3 winners

Best Use of Channel3

$1,500 cash

1 winner

Best Use of Render – 1st Place

$1,000 Render Credits

1 winner

Best Use of Render – 2nd Place

$750 Render Credits

1 winner

Best Use of Render – 3rd Place

$500 Render Credits

1 winner

Judging Criteria

Projects will be evaluated across the following criteria:

Technological Implementation

Judges will evaluate how thoroughly and skillfully the project uses the **PayPal Developer Platform and AI tools**, including whether it demonstrates genuine effort and a working, non-trivial implementation.

Design

The project should provide a complete and coherent product experience rather than being only a technical proof of concept.

Potential Impact

The project should make a credible and specific case for solving a real problem for a real audience, and the demonstrated solution should actually address that problem.

Innovation / Idea

Judges will consider how creative and novel the concept is and how it differs from existing concepts.

Presentation

The video should clearly demonstrate the project working end-to-end.

The presentation should communicate:

- What problem is being solved
- Who the project is for
- Why the problem matters
- How the solution works

The overall presentation should also be easy to follow.

Get Started

Participants can get started by:

- Creating a **PayPal Developer account**.
- Reviewing the available example projects.
- Brainstorming and developing their own project.
- Building with the PayPal Developer Platform and an AI tool of their choice.

Webinars

The provided information lists the following webinars:

- **6 October:** Start Building with PayPal
- **7 October:** Power Your PayPal Hackathon Project with APIMatic Context Plugins
- **12 October:** Build a Payments Dashboard Without Building a Dashboard
- **13 October:** Start Building with PayPal

Key Highlights

- Global **online hackathon by PayPal**.
- Open to developers, designers, founders, students, and builders.
- Participants must be above the legal age of majority in their country of residence.
- Individual participation and team participation are allowed.
- No fixed problem statements or tracks.
- Participants can build an AI agent, application, automation, payment experience, business tool, social product, or other innovative solution.
- **PayPal + AI integration is mandatory.**
- Free PayPal sandbox environment can be used.
- Any AI tool, model, or platform can be used.
- Working prototype or proof of concept is required.
- Public GitHub repository is required.
- Demo video must be under **3 minutes**.
- Total listed cash prizes are **$67,500+**, plus additional prizes.
- Multiple special awards are available.
